

Session 1: Joseph and the Messianic Mosaic

Key Takeaways

- The Yoseph story is about God transforming betrayal into a vehicle for blessing and rescue.
- The biblical authors shaped the Yoseph story to enrich the developing portrait of the promised messiah.

Yaaqov's Sons in the Biblical Imagination

The stories found in Genesis 37-50 bring the narrative of the Genesis scroll to its climax, as Yaaqov's family is nearly destroyed by the jealous rivalry of his sons. The older brothers' envy of the youngest brother, Yoseph, sets in motion a chain of events that ultimately results in the salvation of the family from a terrible famine.

Below is a basic overview of the story.

Act 1—Genesis 37:2-41:57

Genesis 37a

- The beloved **Yoseph** dreams about being **elevated as ruler**

Genesis 37b

- a - Yoseph is kidnapped by jealous brothers
- b - **Reuven's failed plan** vs. **Yehudah's** successful plan = Yoseph enslaved in Egypt
- a' - Jealous **sons deceive father**

Genesis 38

- **Yehudah's** seed **rescued from ruin through the deception of his disguised** daughter Tamar

Genesis 39-41

- Slave **Yoseph is elevated as ruler** over Egypt

Act 2 — Genesis 42:1-45:25a

Genesis 42

- Because of famine, brothers go down to Egypt and are tested by a **disguised and deceptive** Yoseph who keeps one brother as a slave

Genesis 43-44

- Famine; **Deceptive** Yoseph again tests his brothers with beloved Binyamin
- **Reuven's failed plan** vs. **Yehudah's** successful intercession, offers himself as slave in Egypt

Genesis 45a

- Yoseph reveals his **disguise and deceptive test, rescues the seed of Yaaqov's seed from ruin**

Act 3 — Genesis 45:25b-50:26

45b-46a

- Yaaqov's family goes down to **ruler Yoseph** in Egypt, led by **Yehudah**

46b-47

- Yoseph rescues his family and the nations during the famine

48-50

- Yaaqov **blesses Yoseph**, **elevates Yehudah**, and **demotes Reuven**
- Promise of exodus up out of Egypt

Genesis 37:2-41:57 (Vertical). Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This ancient story of the sons of Yaaqov is not simply of historical interest for the biblical authors. Like the rest of the Genesis scroll, it serves as a template through which the biblical authors saw their entire world. These narratives of the past anticipate the rest of the story, which will focus on the descendants of these same rival sons.

Later Recollections: The Story of Yaaqov's Sons

- Numbers 13-14: Spies from the 12 tribes are sent to investigate the promised land. Joshua (from Ephrayim of Yoseph) and Caleb (from Yehudah) are the only spies among all the 12 tribes who trust Yahweh; the others die in exile while these two inherit the land.
- 1 Kings 11:26-40: The 10 northern tribes of Israel are led by Jeroboam son of Yoseph to rebel against Solomon son of Yehudah, and so the tribes divide into two kingdoms. Solomon is jealous and tries to kill Jeroboam, who flees into exile in Egypt (!).

- Ezekiel 37:15-22: Ezekiel develops the portrait of Yoseph's reconciliation with his brothers in Genesis 45-50, and he anticipates the final reconciliation of the brothers. He highlights the tribes of Yoseph and Yehudah as two separate groups that will be one, and their reunion will signal the inheritance of a renewed Eden.
- Zechariah 10:6-10: Zechariah sees Israel's past exile in Egypt as an image of Israel's present exile, and the division of the brothers as an image of Israel's scattering that will be reversed by yet another exodus and reconciliation of the family.
- 1 Chronicles 5:1-2: In this recollection of the family line of Yisrael, the Chronicler (who lives long after the Babylonian exile) reflects back on the reversal of birth order recounted in Genesis 37-50. But he also sees how that reversal anticipates the entire history of rivalry between the tribes of Yehudah and Yoseph narrated in the Former Prophets (Joshua-Kings).

1 Chronicles 5:1-2 NASB*

¹ And the sons of Reuven the **firstborn** of Yisrael
(for he was the **firstborn**,
but because he defiled his father's bed,
his **firstborn-right** was given to the sons of Yoseph the son of Israel;
and so he is not enrolled in the genealogy according to the firstborn-right.

² However, Yehudah proved more mighty among his brothers,
and from him came the leader,
yet the **firstborn-right** belonged to Yoseph)

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

- Acts 7:9-29: In Stephen's final speech before he is murdered, he recounts the story of the Torah and Prophets, focusing specially on two rulers in Israel who were rejected by their brothers: Yoseph and Moses. He sees a deep parallel between both figures, who were chosen by God to rule and deliver, but who were rejected and persecuted by their own family members. Stephen argues that this pattern has repeated itself in the rejection of Jesus Messiah by the leaders of Israel in his own day.

The Point

Later biblical authors see the story of Yoseph, Yehudah, and the division and reconciliation of the family as a forward preview of the entire history of Israel leading up to the messianic age.

These past stories were designed to display a pattern that kept repeating itself through Israel's history, leading up to the time of Jesus and the apostles.

For the biblical authors, the key to understanding their present and future was found in these narrative about their past. The past anticipates the future, and the present maps onto what has come before and what will come later.

Reflection Question

According to Jesus in Luke 24:44-47, what is the Hebrew Bible about? How should this guide the way we read the Joseph story?